An Old Ape Fossil Found in Egypt

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Scientists have found a very old ape **fossil** in Egypt. It may change what we know about where apes, and humans, first came from. The new ape is called Masripithecus moghraensis. It lived about 17 to 18 million years ago. Its bones were found at Wadi Moghra in northern Egypt. It is the first true **fossil** ape ever found in North Africa. A team from Egypt and the University of Southern California wrote about the find in the **journal** Science. For a long time, scientists thought early apes lived mostly in southern Africa. North Africa had given us old monkey **fossils**, but never an ape. This find may fill that gap. "We spent five years searching for this kind of **fossil**," said Hesham Sallam, a scientist at Mansoura University. The ape belongs to a group called **crown Hominoidea**. Only the ape's lower **jaw** was found. The **jaw** is very strong, with big **canine** teeth. The ape probably ate mostly fruit, but its strong teeth could also **crush** nuts and seeds.

Word Treasure

fossil -- A fossil is the remains of a living thing from long ago.

crown Hominoidea -- Crown Hominoidea is the group of all living apes and their shared ancestors.

canine -- Canine teeth are the sharp, pointed teeth near the front of the mouth.

jaw -- A jaw is the part of the face that holds the teeth.

crush -- To crush means to press something hard until it breaks.

journal -- A journal is a magazine where scientists share new findings.

Background you need

Apes are animals like chimpanzees and gorillas, and humans are their close cousins.

Fossils are the remains of living things from long ago.

Break it down

WHO: Hesham Sallam and scientists from Egypt and the USA
WHAT: A very old ape fossil found in Egypt
WHERE: Wadi Moghra in northern Egypt
WHY: To learn where apes and humans first came from

Why it matters

Finding old bones helps us learn where we came from, like solving a puzzle about your own family.

Test what you remember

1. How old is the ape?

(A) About 170 to 180 million years old
(B) About 17 to 18 million years old
(C) About 1.7 to 1.8 million years old
(D) About 17,000 years old

2. Where was the fossil found?

(A) Southern Africa
(B) South America
(C) Wadi Moghra in northern Egypt
(D) Northern Europe

3. What is the ape called?

(A) A gorilla
(B) Homo sapiens
(C) A chimpanzee
(D) Masripithecus moghraensis

4. What part of the ape was found?

(A) Only a skull
(B) Only the lower jaw
(C) Only a foot bone
(D) A whole skeleton

5. What did the ape probably eat?

(A) Only fish
(B) Mostly fruit, but also nuts and seeds
(C) Only meat
(D) Only leaves

6. How long did scientists search for this kind of fossil?

(A) Fifty years
(B) Ten years
(C) Five years
(D) One year

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):